

THE DESIGNER DECADES

In the modern age, fashion designers have become celebrities, and fashion weeks and couture shows part of the news cycle. Designers repeatedly push boundaries, finding ever more theatrical and experiential ways to present their collections, from machines spray-painting models' dresses at Alexander McQueen's Spring/Summer 1999 show to a blast-off rocket at Chanel for Autumn/Winter 2017. The power of the brand, from Armani to Burberry, has become international – designers' names sell products. Calvin Klein's fragrances, for example, sell an aspirational lifestyle, and his underwear line in the 1990s was so famous that the garment became known simply by the designer's name.

Inclusive fashion

Fashion has made strides to become more inclusive in the modern era, to reflect modern society. Towards the end of the 20th century signature looks from style tribes – from rappers to surfers – became increasingly mainstream, as fashion designers took influence from the street and re-worked styles, and the mass-market followed the trend. In the new century fashion started to bring diversity in to the mainstream. So Winnie Harlow, who "... just happens to have vitiligo", took her place on an equal footing with fellow models, while amputee Jack Eyers walked for Teatum Jones in a show that mixed menswear and womenswear on the same platform. Fashion embraced gender fluidity too, with looks by menswear designer Craig Green worn by women in 2015. Multi-culturalism also started to be placed centre stage. For example, H&M, the second largest fashion retailer in the world, featured a Muslim woman wearing a hijab in promotional material.

Instant fashion

Communication became truly global with the invention of the internet and social media. Fashion, too, became more international, with production shifting from Europe and North America to Asia, and fashion weeks taking place throughout the world, from Ghana and Pakistan to Mexico and New Zealand. The cycle of increased production and consumption from the 1990s onwards led to the success of high-street, mass-market stores such as Zara and Victoria's Secret. After the financial crisis of the later 2000s, budget clothing retailers such as Primark and Walmart experienced a boom in business and they, along with the explosion of online shopping sites, have sped up the way that fashion is consumed. However, an increasing awareness of "fast fashion", and of the effects of the fashion industry in general on our world, has led to an acceleration of ethical fashion, with designers Vivienne Westwood and Stella McCartney leading the charge for change.



1980–81

1981

Lady Diana Spencer marries Prince Charles. She wears an ivory silk wedding dress designed by David and Elizabeth Emanuel. It sets the fashion for wedding dresses for at least the next 10 years.

► Diana's wedding dress had puffed sleeves and a 7.5-m (25-ft) train

1981

Music Television (MTV) is born and brings pop-star styles to a global audience.

▲ MTV brought star style to popular consciousness

1981

The first episode of the US TV series *Dynasty* airs and helps to popularize power dressing and shoulder pads.

▼ The cast of *Dynasty* set 1980s fashion trends



1982–84



1983

Jean Paul Gaultier launches his *Le Dadaïsme* collection, which includes his signature corset.

1984

Polo Ralph Lauren flagship store is built in New York City.

1984

Donna Karan International is established.

1984

The first London Fashion Week takes place, produced by Lynne Franks. BodyMap's shows both shock and wow with their highly innovative use of print and lycra clubwear worn by models of all shapes, sizes, and ages.

► Bold black and white design by BodyMap

1985–88

1985

With her jangling jewellery, lace, black mesh vest, and hair bows, Madonna in *Desperately Seeking Susan* becomes a style icon for many women throughout the world.

1985

Dolce & Gabbana's first women's collection is presented in Milan.

1988

Anna Wintour becomes editor-in-chief at *American Vogue*.



1988

Zara, the Spanish fashion retail chain, begins its international expansion, signalling the beginnings of "fast fashion".

